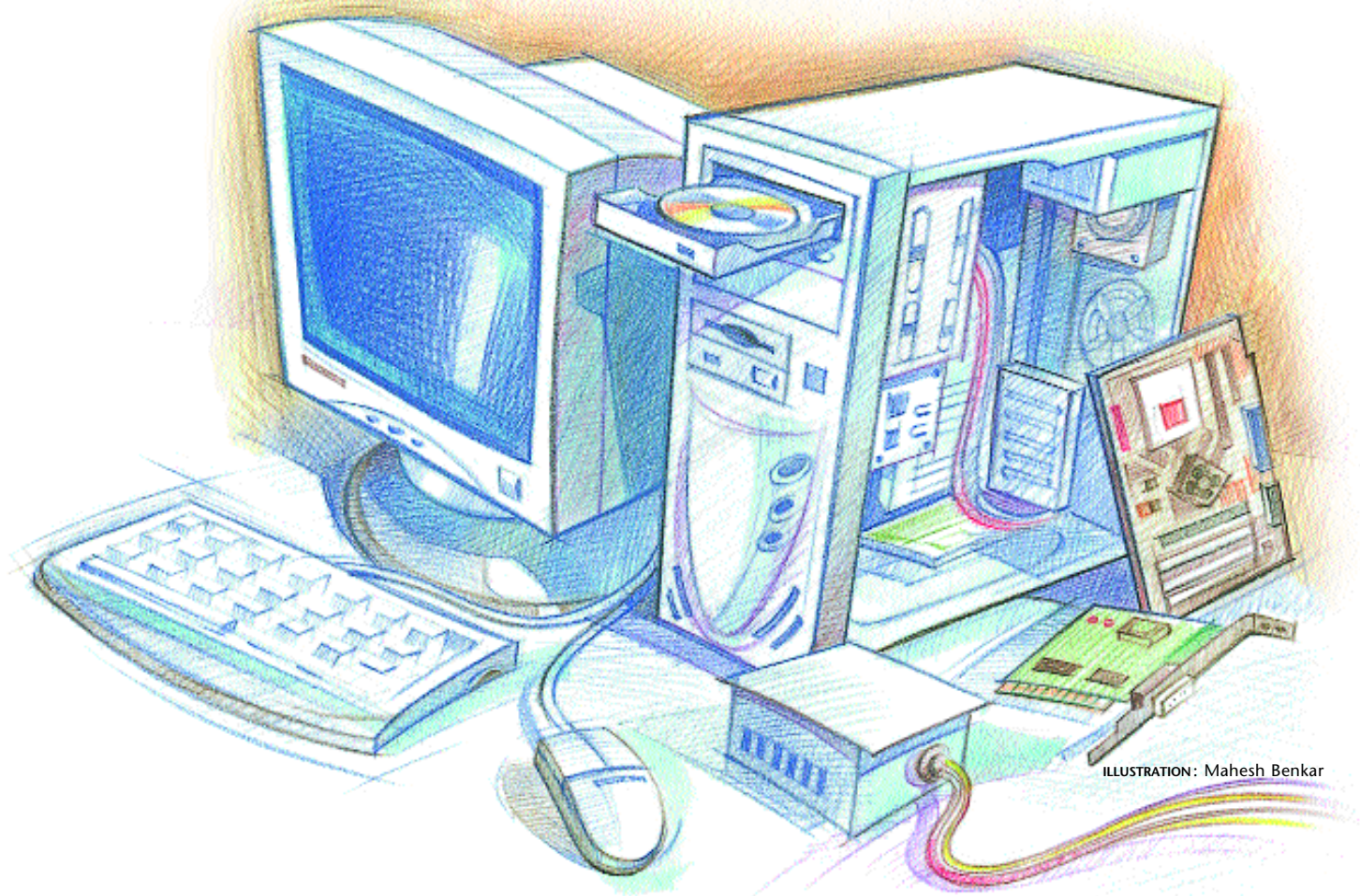




Made to Order

Looking forward to a machine built exactly to your satisfaction? Here's how to select the right assembler who will deliver your dream machine

A system configuration that reads a Pentium 4, a 7,200-rpm 40 GB hard disk drive, 256 MB of RAM, and sprinkled liberally with an assortment of hardware such as a high-powered graphics card, a 17-inch monitor, 5.1 surround sound speakers, an optical mouse, *et al.* All this at a price that is anywhere between 10 to 30 per cent cheaper than similar configurations of branded PCs.

Local assemblers push their concoctions in your face everyday in the form of newspaper advertisements and handouts at the railway station. They promise you the world, all within your earthly budget. While some deliver their promises, others will try to take advantage of an ignorant buyer.

But take heart—you can be the proud

owner of a computer that rivals the best in its price range and still be assured of after-sales support. All you need to do is ask the

right questions, do a bit of background research and look out for possible pitfalls.

Choosing the Right Assembler

- ✓ Chat with friends and relatives who have purchased computers from the same assembler. You can gain a wealth of inside knowledge from them regarding after-sales support and trustworthiness. Trusty assemblers should not hesitate to provide you the names of a few people who have bought from them.
- ✓ Don't buy from a vendor who tries to overwhelm you with technical jargon.
- ✓ Don't buy a computer from a store where the salesperson makes you feel like you're not worth their time—if this is the

way they treat you while you're buying a system, you could well imagine what after-sales service would be like.

- ✓ Find out if the company has any quality certifications such as ISO 9000—this would spell better quality products and attention to detail.
- ✓ Find out if the vendor has any other branches and what the strength of their after-sales force is. Preferably, choose a vendor that is located within an hour's driving distance from where the computer is installed.